A STORY OF YESTERDAY

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Chapter 1

I

The clock had recently ticked eleven and twenty. I think it was Thursday, my last memory went back to Tuesday night and I was in the habit of not dying more than two days in a row.

My presence, among others, made *The Temple* one of the saddest bars in the city today. A good part of those of us who were there, in our own way, were losers. I had set out to waste my time in each of the ice cubes in my glass when I awoke to the unison of a different voice than usual on a Thursday night after eleven o´clock. I hadn't even heard the sound of the door.

“A beer please,” replied.

The girl's cigarette gave off that shocking pink smoke reserved for the female gender. I was watching her for over twenty minutes. In the meantime, she had finished three cigarettes, solemnly elaborating her own end. As she got ready to start the fourth, she came over to where I was and asked: “Do you have a light?”

“Yes... of course,” I replied, surprised.

She lit the cigarette near me. How long it had been since a woman didn't.

“Thanks.”

I replied with a grimace and dared to ask her: “Do you always smoke so much?”

She gave me a smile, the best in almost a year.

“I never stop smoking for more than five minutes at a time.”

“What about while you sleep?” I asked.

“When I sleep, I am not responsible for my actions.”

We smiled at the same time.

She was neither a redhead nor a blonde but both. She shouldn't be over twenty years old. However, she behaved like a woman.

“You don't come here much, do you?”

“No, I don't like bars, I only frequent them on special occasions.”

I didn't understand what could be special about a bar after eleven o'clock on a Thursday night. I didn't risk asking her. Since I started visiting *The Temple*, I had started a new hobby that consisted of contemplating the shoes of each woman I sighted. Today I hadn't done it, her way of smoking had absorbed me more. She took three coins out of her pocket. One fell to the ground and then I immediately bent down to pick it up. Now it was impossible not to stare at those pointy shoes.

“Thank you,” she smiled.

“Your shoes look great on you.”

The left one had a sky-green color understated to the low light of the place. The right one, on the other hand, had a darker hue.

“You're the first man to tell me that.”

“I'm pretty sure I was the first to notice,” I replied.

She left double what she had consumed as a tip. The best I had ever seen here.

“We'll see each other again.”

She left without leaving me the right to say anything.

The few people who knew me called me Victor. I was born in a small town on the outskirts of Madrid, where I spent my childhood and part of my adolescence, until I started working as a salesman at the age of seventeen. At thirty-one I got married and at forty I began to visit *The Temple* systematically. I have never considered suicide after my wife's death. I thought if I was still here, it had to make some sense to go on living.

My tall figure had been disguising a weight that lately had advanced inversely proportional to my quality of life. The last time I stepped on a scale I weighed over 250 pounds... It was two months ago, in the hospital, when the cocaine did give me a warning again. Although I was no more honest than wretched, I could not sleep well. Several mistakes doomed my conscience every night and certain parts of the day.

II

Today's Sunday at *The Temple* was like the one seven days ago.

An elderly couple was discussing about Russian centralism; next to them, a loner must have been thinking something related to the couple and Russian centralism. Situated at the far end of the bar, a group of young men were competing for two girls who knew more about boys than Russians.

The Temple was not too big, but big enough to go unnoticed. On the right-hand side of the entrance, a pair of electronic targets accompanied a television close to the ceiling. The corridor, about forty feet long, supported the bar behind which Julio worked every day. In front of it, there were eight small tables and a calendar with some notes. At the end of the corridor, tiny ascending stairs featured a space of tables, chairs and bathrooms for both sexes.

It had both a gloomy and subdued appearance, due to the placement and intensity of the lighting. About twenty small lights, placed both on the ceiling and on the walls, pierced the darkness creating an atmosphere more akin to a nightclub than a conventional tavern.

Located at the top, as I called the part of the bathrooms, and embedded in the middle of the ceiling, a light in the form of a circumference created a peculiar chiaroscuro. In one of the more discreet corners, while the billowing smoke was disappearing, I thought why the girl with the two-colored hair had caused to meet me. There was always a reason to enter someone's life, either for a while or for a lifetime. It was eleven o'clock when all that was left was an old drunk who was screaming about having

been on another planet and me. Half an hour later, after helping Julio to dislodge the abducted guy, I disappeared along with a sadness as bitter as the narcotic that preceded ten hours of rest.

Today was Friday again. It was a Friday of yellow sky, different from the previous one. During the morning it had been raining and the yellow reflection of the water drops transmitted me a mixture of attention and alacrity.

Tonight, the reasons for my visit to *The Temple* would be different than usual. I was sure that she would keep her word to see me again. Friday, like any other day, evoked loneliness, drunkenness and bad mood. After eight o'clock, I woke up from an empty sleep. I showed up too early, without having any dinner, so as not to forget to be polite. *The Temple* was perhaps the place that had most often seen me reduced myself to misery. For that reason, today, I decided to go down earlier. The many minutes that passed until midnight approached, served to remind me of some unimportant stories from here. Like when by chance I was chosen as bait for two teenagers who claimed to offer me their bodies if I would teach them how to use them...

The girl didn't come all night, so before returning home, I asked Julio to make me a sandwich.

III

Today, Wednesday, I was just having a drink and chatting about something unimportant, when I saw that cloud of pinkish smoke expanding in the polluted air. I became restless as if I were a teenager fresh out of childhood.

“What a surprise!” I exclaimed.

“Don't you like them?” asked as she removing smoke from her lungs.

“Surprises? To some extent they make you react more naturally, and that's always good, isn't it?”

“Maybe that's why I decided to come today,” smiled.

“Julio, give me the usual and a beer.”

We had met twice and didn't even know each other's names.

“Well... I'll get ahead of your question.”

“Lara,” answered quickly.

She dared to guess and got it right. My name was accompanied by a grimace-like gesture.

“You wouldn't happen to like rock and roll, would you?” I asked.

“Yes. Why not?” she answered as she sipped her beer.

I drained my drink and suggested:

“I know a place near here. If you'd like to join me.”

We barely exchanged a few words during the short ride.

“You've never been here before?”

“No. It doesn't ring a bell.”

“Every day they play different music, on Wednesdays they always play R&R. Look at the sign,” I pointed to a sign that read *'Rock and Roll Music'*. “Every day of the week, they change the letters of the first words depending on the music being playing.”

“It doesn't look like a bad place,” replied Lara, who kept smoking.

Before opening the front door, I ventured to identify *Hook Line and Sinker* the music I could very slightly distinguish. Going down the stairs, we reach a huge dance floor only interrupted by a score of tables and the typical bar area. Meanwhile, numerous tiny clouds of colorful smoke, formed by cigarettes of all shades, filtered out of the corners.

Songs by Big Joe Turner, Elvis Presley, The Beatles, Jerry Lee Lewis, The Big Bopper, Bill Haley, Chuck Berry, Bo Diddley, Little Richard, Buddy Holly, Carl Perkins and Ritchie Valens, among others, played.

I wouldn't have been able to dance with her if she had asked me to, I wasn't ready yet. At a small table, Lara was looking into my eyes, as if she wanted to see through them. We seemed to be playing a game of which I didn't know the rules. The clock struck three when I glanced at it. There were only two couples left at the tables and on the dance floor two groups of five and three people. At half past three we ruled our absence.

“Did you like the place?”

“Yes,” she replied cheerfully. “It's great.”

When we left, I decided to invite her to have a drink at my house. I considered it as an act of courtesy and little attachment to loneliness. At no time had I thought of sleeping with her, nor do I think I could have. After more than ten months without my wife, the female company was at least shocking to me. We headed for my apartment because she was seduced by the invitation. On the way, we only got to know a few unimportant things about each other.

The apartment was comfortable and small. It was tastefully decorated, just as Monica left it before she died. The walls were maroon in color and circular in shape. The ceiling, on the other hand, was made of symmetrical white slats. Ten small Venetian masks arranged in a staggered pattern next to the television set caught Lara's eye.

“It's small, but it's enough for me.”

Lara's giggle gave me the go-ahead.

“I'm going to wash my hands, leave things wherever you want. You have another bathroom next to the first room.”

When I finished, I prepared two glasses that I placed on a small table next to the armchair. I thought about moving the photographs of my wife, but I didn't and waited for Lara to return. She returned with the most beautiful face. However, she had an unusual expression of sadness on her face. She sat down next to me and immediately asked me: “Do you remember Ines Jurado? And the shortcut on Ribera Street?”

I felt a strong shiver and my muscles atrophied in such a way that I was unable to say a word. When I put my hand into my pocket as best I could, I felt a deep stabbing near my heart. Something like a stiletto had pierced my body. The young woman, between sobs, repeated the operation three times, the third stab being the one that ended my life. Before dying, I stammered only four words: “She was my wife.”

Chapter 2

I

This year, to the people of Madrid, winter had taken them by surprise. Who knows if for this reason, had been too many days ahead of the date assigned to appear. It was Tuesday. For the girl who was returning home, a useless and disgusting Tuesday, after knowing that she had failed in Descriptive Geometry. From her house to the university, it was no more than five minutes in her sister's car, but the return was different, because she could not return that way and the time she spent waiting for the bus, she spent walking. At a brisk pace, a little more than twenty minutes. Crossing through a long, wasteland, a little less than half of it.

The crossing, orphaned of transit, seemed to meet all the necessary requirements to guarantee the outcome of anyone who decided to commit a crime. It had no lighting, only that which came from the adjacent street lights. Thinking about this, there were few who dared to cross it. The student, who had only crossed it during the day, decided to do so tonight, mainly because of her desire to get home soon, go to bed and forget about the cold and today's day.

On alert, she set out to cross the wasteland as soon as possible. Shortly before reaching the end, where civilization is restored, a handkerchief impregnated with a colorless liquid hit her nostrils. Instantly, the girl became dizzy and fell disoriented to the ground. The attacker quickly moved the body to some nearby bushes that he used as a mask and shelter.

He tore off her underwear and stabbed her vagina more than ten times. The victim's face expressed a mixture of pain and disbelief. Helpless, she could neither move nor express the words of help that instinctively tried to escape on their own.

After a short time, the guy, of whom only two small eyes were visible, stopped for a few seconds. Then he took out the handkerchief again and placed it stealthily on the face of the young woman who, without realizing it, was losing her life.

At around eight o'clock in the morning, the shortcut was cordoned off by the local police. Shortly before, some students had found the girl's body on their way to the university.

The horrible news came to her over the phone as she was getting ready for breakfast. Lara's nervous eyes were getting wet. From her mouth emerged the most shuddering screams and before finishing the call, she fainted due to a strong anxiety crisis.

II

Three months had passed since what had happened. Three months since the girl with the two-colored hair had set out to catch her sister's murderer. She had achieved absolutely nothing that would allow her to start an investigation. There were no witnesses and, as it usually happens in these cases, no suspects.

“Hello?” she answered sleepily as she lit a cigarette.

The phone had rung too early for a Saturday.

“Hello. Lara Jurado?”

“Yes, it's me,” she answered.

“My name is Rosa. I have some information that you may be interested in. I'd like to see you in person.”

“What information?” she answered suspiciously.

“Yes, related to your sister. I'd like to help you. We'll meet in an hour at *The Morning Café*. Is that okay?”

“That's fine. But...” at that moment the phone went dead on the other line.

She just wanted to ask her who she was and how she had gotten her phone number. Then she thought she would do it later. She had seemed to her to be an older woman and quite friendly, but she doubted her call. Lara did not know *The Morning Café* in detail. She had passed by it on several occasions, but only once she had had breakfast there. It looked like a small, forgotten inn, but it enjoyed a certain fame. The one called Rosa arrived a few minutes late. Lara had appeared too punctual.

“¿Lara?”

“Yes, it's me,” she affirmed, a little uncertain.

“Forgive me for being late, daughter. Order whatever you want, it's on me,” she had to be between seventy and seventy-five years old. Of simple and affable appearance, rather plump, she looked good.

“Do we sit down?” asked the woman, pointing to the nearest table.

They sat across from each other. They looked into each other's eyes while their coffees were being served and the old woman started the conversation.

“Well... it took me a long time to make up my mind and I want to tell you and not the police. If after what I'm going to tell you, you decide to talk to them, I won't have any problem in collaborating. That's up to you, daughter. The night it happened... well, that night, I was at the window of my house when I saw a man come out of that path. I was at the window for over an hour, and in that time, only that man came out of there. My house is right across the street, I can't see the wasteland, but I can see who comes and goes out of it. At first, I didn't give it any importance, but when I found out what happened...”

Lara was speechless, until she reacted to Rosa's little smile.

“But, then, he can be…”

“I don't know, but the hours match. Although I still haven't told you the most important thing. Two days ago, I saw that man again.”

“What?”

Lara's face was as pale as an angel.

“Yes, in the afternoon. I recognized him right away. I'd rather you find him than the police, if he did that.”

Lara could not assimilate what she was telling her. It seemed like a miracle and she didn't believe in them.

“As I spend many hours peeking out the window, with a little luck, maybe I will see him again and I will be able to follow him.”

“I can't believe it,” she said. “I cannot tell you how grateful I am.”

“You don't have to thank me at all,” she concluded.

Lara's eyes were stuck in the old woman's gaze. After a while she reacted: “Can I ask you a question?”

“Go ahead,” she confirmed, shaking her head slowly.

“You got my number from the phone book, didn't you?”

“Yes, I looked it up. When I found the same last names as your sister's, I assumed you were the person I was looking for.”

“Yes,” she answered, faking a smile.

“Well, Lara, I have to go, my husband is waiting for me. He almost caught me talking to you and he doesn't know anything. That's why I hung you up.”

“Nothing's wrong,” she answered. “You have helped me a lot.”

“I'm going to pay. Bye, girl,” she touched her shoulder and got ready to pay for the coffees.

“Please,” she replied, blowing the colored smoke out of her lungs. “How are you going to pay for this?”

It was hard, but she managed to convince her.

Then the old woman disappeared, and soon after, so did she.

III

The next day, the little free time that her working life allowed her, was used by the young woman to prowl around the shortcut.

The search was unsuccessful. It was logical, because the old woman's indications to identify her sister's alleged murderer were scarce. She told her about a tall, dark and too ordinary man. She trusted Rosa's words a lot. Mainly because she needed a culprit and would have paid anything for any information. Secondly, because it was hard to believe that an old woman was lying to her. Thus, several weeks went by where Lara took advantage of any moment to go to the waste ground. She had thought a lot about what she would do if she was lucky enough to find that guy and a small reminiscence invaded her brain in the form of an aphorism: *In revenge, as in love, the woman is more barbarous than the man*.

She had also thought about how utopian the matter turned out to be and knew that it was very likely that the delinquent was far enough away that Rosa would never see him again. Even though she was passionate about the first premise, she knew that the second was more likely to be true.

A few months after Rosa's visit, she received another call.

Just to hear it seemed to her the best prize. The girl's investigation was as empty as that of the police, who had not been able to obtain any evidence. They agreed to meet again at *The Morning Café*. Rosa's face showed that there would be no lack of good news.

“Hello, beautiful.”

“Hello Rosa. How are you?” she answered.

“I have very good news.”

Automatically, Lara's smile was drawn as it had been for a long time.

“Have you seen him again?” she answered excitedly.

“Yes,” she smiled. “I've seen him twice. The first time, I was able to follow him to a place called...” she took a small note out of her pocket. “*The Temple*,” said slowly. “The other, I couldn't follow him to the end, because a neighbor interrupted me to say hello, but I have the feeling that he went to the same place, at least, until I stopped following him, I was doing the same route as the other time.”

Lara was astonished. She knew she could never make up for what Rosa had done for her, but at least it was a little comfort to know that she would feel good if she listened to her old personal stories.

IV

Now she spent her free time thinking about what to do when she was in front of him.

Of all the options, she chose a chance encounter. When she was sure she was in front of her sister's murderer, she would kill him with treachery. For a few days she busied herself inspecting *The Temple*. She had never been there, which was a trump card in her favor.

She had seen, on numerous occasions, a man who met the characteristics described by Rosa. She had always done it from the outside, as she preferred that no one recognize her when she entered for the first time. As a day she chose a Thursday night. It would be too late for there to be to be many people left and too early to close a bar.

Chapter 3

I

Under the small white slats, lying on top of the dark armchair, my body was camouflaged. Although at times I had considered that we are all waiting in a big queue in front of death, I had never thought enough about the end of it, not even when I felt the pangs near my heart. It's such a short second that it doesn't let you do it. As a reflex action, moments before losing life completely, small memories of all times manifest in memory. In my story, good memories abounded, but they were far away from the present time. They were only a few seconds, but enough to make me remember that memory had played dirty, hiding from me those pleasant memories that were expressed inside me. Before dying, I remembered a phrase that my father repeated with certain frequency, he said something like that the true equality of the human being was the taste of death. The elongated armchair in my house had been the place that chance had chosen to do so. I don't think I would have preferred anything else. In the end, it was a privileged death.

II

Lara looked as if she had been struck by lightning. She didn't quite understand what she had done when, after removing my hand from my body and searching my pocket, she only found a half-open wallet. No trace of any object that could have injured her. She wanted to see me dead, but after confessing responsibility for the crime. Even though she had committed a murder, she tried to convince herself without success that she had done the right thing and had acted in self-defense. She was very nervous and could not open my wallet. When she did, she set out to register it. A passport-sized photo of a pretty woman was the first thing she saw. The rest, a few coins and several cards. She immediately connected the photograph with my last words. She concluded that the hand I put in my pocket was not looking for a harmful object, but for the image of my wife. But that did not exonerate me from her suspicions, but added more difficulty to her particular investigation. It took her several minutes to rummage through my figure. She did not discover even one incriminating piece of evidence, which involved snooping around the house. She took a handkerchief out of her pocket in order to cover her tracks and started where she was. There were four photos of the one Lara had already identified as my wife.

She took out a cigarette and continued to search unsuccessfully for anything of interest in the drawers and cupboards of the living room under the lifeless gaze of its owner.

She moved down the hallway and into a small bedroom that she instinctively assigned as ours. The aesthetics of the sleeping room had a strong resemblance to the living room. After searching through some drawers near the double bed, she located numerous bills in a woman's

name. She did not take them and wrote that name down on her cell phone. She returned to the living room and placed herself on the opposite side of the couch in which I was resting on. With watery eyes, she remained watching me for four cigarettes. Trying to make sense of things, she came to think that she might have made a mistake.

She had found no evidence linking me to her sister Ines. Just a single piece of evidence that she kept wondering about. She didn't understand why my expression became so different when she asked me for her sister's name and the crime scene.

III

Gradually, her head became aware of reality and she began to think about what she would do with my corpse. Precipitously, she rejected the craziest ideas and decided not to move it from its place. Leaning both hands on the armchair, she raised herself upwards and went to the body. She took the wallet she had fumbled with and the cigarette butts so as not to make the police's job easier, and after a glance around, she disappeared without a trace. It took her a long walk to arrive. Afterwards, she prepared a well-loaded joint, which did not help her to attenuate the effects of the murder. She took off the clothes that bore small bloodstains and put them in a bag next to the stiletto. In the first place, she would not return to *The Temple* or to the music place. As she convinced herself of the difficulty of being caught with the help of these small precautions, she dozed off on the pillow.

The day after killing a man dawned similar to that of a hangover. Her head ached a little and the murder seemed like a bad dream. After perceiving reality in the form of a bloody bag, she hurriedly lined it with four more, and walked down the stairs in search of the garbage can. As she had no appetite, she skipped the meal and entered the name of the woman she had written down on her cell phone last night into the computer. A multitude of similar entries appeared. The first one, entitled: *Chance discovers the body of a woman who disappeared days ago*, referred to the discovery of Monica Robles' body by a bungee jumping fan. Lara could not believe what she was reading. The news said something like this: *A young man finds the body of the missing Monica Robles as the result of an*

incredible coincidence. The rope that was supposed to block the young man's fall, broke and he fell into the water. After emerging from the depth, he shouted that he had found a corpse.

The boy stated minutes later:

"When I was underwater, I thought I saw at the bottom part of a person's face in something like a huge bag."

The headline of another news, referred to the confirmation by the police that the corpse in the sports bag, together with many stones, belonged to the missing woman. Lara immediately searched through the multitude of other records that had appeared. She ignored those that did not contribute anything different and observed several headlines referring to the autopsy performed on the woman. The texts confirmed the hypothesis that the police were considering. The autopsy revealed that Monica Robles died instantly as a victim of the hit received on the left temple. The coroner determined that the body was thrown into the water without life and ratified that she had been subjected to a post mortem sexual aggression. Due to the complicated conditions in which she was found, he estimated the date of death to be six or seven days before the discovery, which implied the need to question me because the complaint had been made three days after my wife's death. Perplexed, she focused her attention on the dates of the publications. The body had been found seven days after her sister's murder and based on the coroner's criteria; Monica's death was around the same date as her sister Ines'. She was dumbfounded, she didn't understand anything.

IV

She leaned back in a small, shabby-looking armchair and over a cigarette pondered several hypotheses.

For whatever reason, Monica could have discovered the murder and I would have decided to take her life to avoid accusations. Thus, all the photographs that Lara had seen of my wife, could have placed them with the sole purpose of never forgiving me for what I had supposedly done. She also thought that I could be a multiple murderer, who having killed my wife, would have decided to take the lives of several women. At first, the first theory seemed to her the most obvious and also the most credible, although she was not even certain that she had killed the culprit of Ines' death. Between theories, her thoughts were more and more uncomfortable, she felt that until she knew exactly what had happened, the feeling of uneasiness that had increased with the last discovery would not disappear. Until now, Rosa had been her only and best help and although she had no intention of bothering her, she had proposed to call her if in a couple of weeks, she hadn't done so.

Only six nights had passed. Lara had felt them as the worst since she had received the call from the police a few months ago. She was going crazy. Every day that passed she thought more and understood less, and what weighed her down the most was not being able to share it with anyone. She barely left home and for her, the world consisted of only three people. She would have liked to keep the time frame she had decided on six

days ago, but she could feel herself wasting away and with her everything she needed to know.

“Hello?” a male voice answered.

Then she hung up the phone.

She deduced that he was Rosa's husband and remembered her words in *The Morning Café*. Sentimental relationships between women of any age were something really popular. Lara thought that this was the only reason Rosa wanted her husband not to know about the meetings between the two of them. So, she decided that later she would try again. A few hours later she repeated the call.

“Hello?” answered the male voice again.

After two seconds, Lara answered:

“Hello, good afternoon, is Mrs. Rosa there?”

“Yes, she is here. Who is asking for her?”

“We are making an electoral survey about the next municipal elections. If you would be so kind as to put her on the phone,” improvised the young woman.

“Yes, I'll put her on,” replied the old man.

Meanwhile, the girl smiled slightly.

“Hello Rosa, it's Lara. Forgive me for bothering you. I do need to talk to you. Can we meet?”

“Hello,” whispered the old woman. “Is tomorrow at five o'clock in the afternoon convenient for you?”

“Okay. Thank you very much Rosa.”

“I have to leave you; my husband is hanging around here. Goodbye.”

A cigarette followed the smiling gesture that had triggered the satisfaction of having made the appointment.

V

The old woman was sitting at one of the first tables of *The Morning Café* when Lara came through the door. She was smiling, but not like the other times.

“Hello, young lady. How beautiful you look.”

“You always know how to get a smile out of me,” she replied complacently.

“I'm sorry I barely let you talk yesterday. My husband was nearby and I couldn't dawdle,” smiled Rosa.

“Don't worry, I'm the one who has to apologize for calling at your house.”

“You can do it whenever you want. As long as it's a different survey my husband doesn't have to suspect anything.”

It seemed, judging by each smile, that the two women had known each other for years.

“Rosa, I have to tell you something, do you remember the man you told me about? I've been following him, I've even talked to him, but I haven't found a single clue that makes me think I'm doing things right... I needed to tell someone about it.”

Lara's clear eyes shed two small tears.

“Don't cry. I'm delighted to listen to you and help you in any way I can.”

The young woman's hand slid through her two-colored hair while her gaze thanked Rosa for her last words.

“Do you want me to give you some advice?”

“Go ahead,” she said.

“Until you are completely sure of his innocence, don't quit your investigation.”

“I will continue trying to find out everything I can about that man,” she answered.

Rosa joined her hands with Lara's.

“Thank you,” she answered, grateful for the kind gesture of the old woman, who a few minutes later said she had to leave.

The girl's arm helped Rosa to get up and she slowly disappeared. Lara trusted her, but a foreboding feeling struck her to follow her. She felt strange to be spying on the only person who had helped her. However, she felt an obligation to do so. She needed to check that she was not lying when she placed her home near the wasteland. Rosa was walking slowly, like any old woman. Lara hid from her sight by stopping at the nearest corner and when the old woman abandoned her perspective, she followed her without arousing suspicion. Rosa's route moved farther and farther away from the shortcut. The young woman was surprised that the hurry she had previously manifested, took her to a place that was not her house. By virtue of the benefit of doubt, she did think that perhaps she could have met her husband somewhere else. The doubt was soon dispelled, when the old woman, rummaging in her small purse, took out a key that worked on the door of a doorway far away from the shortcut.

Lara, who had been watching camouflaged in a hedge, forcefully dragged her legs to a nearby wall where she parked her body. She was puzzled but did not feel betrayed. She thought it was a mix-up and the only way to prove it was to confirm it.

She approached the doorway and took the leaflets from the outside mailbox. Pretending to be a delivery woman, she neatly inserted a flyer into each mailbox, hoping to find the name of the old woman in one of them.

After several names, she suspected that someone was descending the stairs. Lara grabbed the door and halfway between the sidewalk and the doorway, she snorted when she saw a tired old man with pot belly breathing heavily. He was carrying two garbage bags of different sizes.

“Good afternoon,” smiled the old man.

“Good afternoon,” she replied a little nervously. “Go ahead”.

The old man walked awkwardly through the door.

“Thank you.”

“You're welcome,” the young woman replied, returning to her work.

She stopped for a moment on the name of Rosa Lazaro and continued looking for more. She finished the names with a single Rosa at the same time that the old man returned freed from the bags.

VI

At noon the next morning, the girl was standing guard near the doorway. She had parked her cramped yellow car one hundred and thirty or one hundred and forty feet from the building, too far away to be discovered. Inside, Lara smoked a cigarette while keeping her eyes on the doorway and the gaunt colored windows that made up the building. She had changed her eyes to black. She had also dyed her hair and pulled it up in a bun along with a headband. In this way, she thought she would not call Rosa's attention to a coincidence as a consequence of snooping around what could be her neighborhood. Inside the vehicle, the young woman observed the surroundings of the guarded apartment. There was only a good-looking restaurant, a hairdresser's, a convenience store and a couple of blocks of apartments with identical aesthetics.

After two hours with no results, Lara approached the restaurant. It was located on the right-hand side of the doorway and a few feet in front of the car, so that she would not lose sight of her target from the inside. It advertised fish and seafood as its specialty and its price list invited you to try your luck. It was divided into two parts. The one closest to the entrance was the smaller one. The walls and ceiling were covered with tiny stone squares of the same size. In front, a short distance from the main door, separated by a couple of steps, was the other area dedicated entirely to the color white and pink. The radically opposite decoration of the two areas must have been designed to offer the client the possibility of eating in different restaurants within the same one. For Lara, the first one had

produced a better first impression. Besides, her preferred part was also the right one to keep an eye on the small apartment. She chose the table where she would sit to eat. It was situated very close to the huge glass panes that accompanied the entrance door, so as not to distract her attention from the little traffic in the doorway. After observing the occupied tables, it seemed to her that the norm in that area should be to eat tapas. However, she preferred to eat à la carte. She looked around after settling in. While she was trying to make a decision, a young man with a goatee, dressed as a waiter approached her.

“Hello, good morning,” he smiled politely. “To eat?”

“Yes... but with so many dishes I don't know which one to choose.”

“May I?” asked the young man, pointing to the menu.

“Of course,” she answered.

“I would recommend seafood-stuffed shells, hake omelette or fish and seafood grill, which is always cheaper. We also have as specialty of the day turbot in a saffron cream and red mullet with asparagus.”

The young man put a lot of effort into his recommendations and seemed to enjoy it.

“Well...turbot in a saffron cream,” she said after a few seconds.

“Good choice. You'll see how you like it. I'll bring you the tablecloth and the cutlery,” smilingly left to get the things.

The turbot was garnished with a sprig of parsley and thinly sliced potatoes. She thought it was delicious.

“Did you like it?”

“The sauce is one of the best I've ever tasted.”

“It's saffron from La Mancha. I'm glad you liked it.”

Later, he informed Lara of the price of the bill. The young woman added several coins to the final price and after saying goodbye to the waiter

returned to her vehicle.

By all accounts, coffee without tobacco is like meat without salt, so Lara lit a cigarette. After three hours with no relevant events and the ashtray collapsed, she rolled down the co-pilot's window and an abundant pinkish smoke escaped from inside. Soon after, she started the car's engine and tired, left the surveillance.

The next day began like the previous one.

Lara, who had woken up earlier, had breakfast recumbent in the driver's seat. It had been raining during the night and the copper-colored drops of water still reflected on the sidewalks. The yellow reflection was her favorite, instead, she hated the rain of the coppery sky. The glare of it gave her a feeling of isolation and lack of energy.

In the middle of the morning, her indications were confirmed. Rosa was going to the doorway with a shopping trolley. She advanced slowly and fatigued from pushing it while she rubbed the sweat from her forehead. When the old woman entered the doorway, Lara bit her lip and uttered a slight "fuck". She knew that in the event that the old woman had more information that she hadn't wanted to reveal, her experience would be enough to trick her again if she decided to talk to her and demand explanations. So, she made the decision to carry out the illegal thought that had been on her mind since the surveillance began. In a period of time no longer than two weeks, she would check whether she lived alone and her routine habits.

The young woman bit her nails while smiling. She was convinced that Rosa had not killed her sister, but her home could be the right place to find some proof. At noon she went to yesterday's restaurant, and after some delicious shrimps she went home.

The few days that had preceded today had been useless for Lara. She hadn't seen Rosa and was surprised that she didn't even come down to run any errands, which made her think that she didn't live alone. She did not like the dynamic in which the surveillance had entered. To devise a plan with minimum guarantees she needed to check on her at least a couple of times a week. Lara, who was leaning on her fist to keep from falling asleep, reacted quickly when she saw Rosa leave the building. A man she immediately recognized appeared at her back. His feet were in no hurry to get anywhere. He walked beside Rosa, a little slower than her. The old man with the garbage bags she saw a few days ago seemed to be paired with her. Lara moved her head up and down as she associated the voice that answered her call to Rosa, with the familiar voice of the man she greeted. She immediately took a look at her watch. Precisely, one hour and eighteen minutes, was the time it took them to return home.

The following week was a photocopy of the previous one. During the week, Rosa went to buy something accompanied by a shopping trolley or some bags. On Sunday, she went out with that man and it didn't take them more than an hour and a half to return. The following week, it was the same again, with the only exception that one of the days, when Lara had just ordered the menu for lunch, she heard the waiter's voice close to her, addressing other people behind her. In spite of being situated so close to the immense windows that accompanied the entrance door, she was not aware that Rosa and her husband had entered the restaurant.

Lara reacted after five or six seconds. She slowly pushed her table and although the color of her eyes and hair had changed, she ran out of the restaurant.

VII

Around ten o'clock in the morning she parked the vehicle.

Behind her seat, she had placed the black sports bag with the crowbar inside. She also brought a small sandwich and a soft drink in a bag.

The night before, she had been observing all the windows belonging to the first floor as possible escape routes in case of any unforeseen event, because they had no bars. Lara was uneasy to think that the solution to the situation that had arisen as a result of her sister's murder was so close. Prudently, she waited a few minutes after watching the old couple leave. She grabbed the bag and hurried to break into the house. Tiptoeing up the few stairs that led to the first floor. The wooden door was out of keeping with the stale old look of the building due to it was stained with a more effusive copper color than the rest of the elements. Lightly she checked the neighboring door that completed the first floor. Lara quickly extracted the crowbar from the bag and in an instant, opened the door. Near the latch were two small splinters and the inevitable evidence that the entrance had been forced. She placed the bag next to the wall of the small hallway and carefully closed the door. The floor was a straight corridor leading to all the rooms.

There was one more door on the right side than on the other side, and at the end of the corridor there was a small room full of books.

After lurking long enough in the kitchen to realize that she would not get anything there, she entered the living room. In every corner there were photographs of Rosa and her husband. The typical wedding photo caught

her attention, where Rosa's body had lost more than half of her current weight in one fell swoop. She rummaged through all the drawers for more than ten minutes and got an address book. Of the remaining rooms, she was only interested in the master bedroom and the small room.

She did check the old people's bedroom in twice as long as the living room and found absolutely nothing. Without stopping, she went to the small room and began to turn the pages of each of the books in search of a note. Tired of turning pages with no results, she closed the door to the small room to clear the floor space needed to sit down to investigate three small drawers. Based on her calculations, it should be about half an hour before the old couple returned. The first two drawers were filled with figurines and irrelevant souvenirs. The third was full of folders. The first folder was saturated with recipes that hid several pages of newspaper. Meanwhile, Rosa opened the front door without her husband's company. When she approached the lock of her apartment, she discovered that the door had been forced. As quickly as she could she descended the stairs and, on the street, called the police. The officers informed her that they would arrive shortly and advised her to leave her home. The alert to the police helped her to decide to enter the house.

Lara was still locked in the small room reading the newspaper pages. They all referred to her sister's death, but brought nothing new. Instinctively, she turned her head and checked her watch. She hurried to put away the folders and grabbed the papers. Leaving the room, she heard the timid sound of the key unlocking the door. She became very nervous and rushed into the nearest room; the master bedroom.

Rosa did not notice the presence of the sports bag next to the wall and moved very slowly through the hallway in a state of alertness. Lara carefully checked from the room that it was the old woman while she

decided how to act. Unconsciously, pushed by the infinite desire to know any answer, she appeared in the middle of the corridor at the surprised and discolored face of her friend. Rosa was dumbfounded and her whole body trembled.

“What are you doing here?” she replied, surprised and with a very nervous voice.

“You lied to me when you said you lived in front of the waste ground! And what about these papers in your house? You have to tell me everything you know about my sister!”

Rosa looked at her like a child after a big scolding.

“Lara, now you have to go. I do promise I'll tell you.”

“I need to know right now.”

Her look expressed compassion and seemed to have an effect on Rosa.

“Listen to me. You have to leave now. I will tell you, I give you my word.”

“Please,” she begged. “I need to know.”

Suddenly, a loud shout was heard through the door.

“Police, we're coming in!”

Lara's eyes, flooded with tears, looked fixedly at Rosa. After, Lara ran along the corridor looking for the window of the small room. The policeman had covered almost the entire corridor when she jumped through the green window. Without wasting a second, he radioed his partner who was waiting downstairs. She was running with all her might, knowing that breaking and entering was considered a very serious offense and the police were authorized to shoot in order to reduce any alleged burglar. The police officer who was chasing her was constantly threatening to open fire if she did not stop running and surrender. The young woman kept running with no

thought of surrendering. The officer crouched down and, after checking that there was no one around her, fired a shot, which missed her.

Instantly, he warned her that he would shoot again if she did not stop. Lara increased the speed of her run and the agent fired another shot that hit her left leg. The policeman radioed for an ambulance to come urgently and rushed to stop the bleeding that seemed impossible to stop. Lara feared that the shot had hit the femoral artery. The agent's partner who was trying to stop the bleeding came running and positioned himself behind Lara to hold her body. Her vision was blurring, although she could still see how Rosa was struggling to get to her side. She was dying with the feeling of having failed and was not lamenting the early visit of death, but of losing forever the hope of settling the score. When Rosa arrived next to her, she was already dead. The old woman squeezed her in her arms and sobbing she was heard whispering “How badly life has treated you, even to bring forward your death”.

Chapter 4

I

After nine in the evening, I pressed the entry phone.

Rosa was preparing dinner and her husband, sleepy, was fiddling with the TV remote control.

“Carlos, open the door, he's going to be your friend,” Rosa called from the kitchen.

“I'm coming...” he grumbled resentfully for not continuing to be submerged in a light sleep. The old man checked that it was me and opened the door. It had been about two months since I had visited him.

“It's been a long time! How are you,” I asked him as he put his arm around my shoulders.

“You see me, a little older than last time.”

“You had me worried.”

“Blame it on the last order,” he said, smiling. “We'll finish it this week.”

“Yeah, it's happening to me too,” I admitted.

“A lot of work?”

“Today, yes. It's been delayed one sale longer than expected. Look what time it is when I'm always at mid-afternoon.”

Carlos looked at me with his little blue eyes and invited me to sit down in his tidy living room.

Before complying with his request, I approached the kitchen to greet Rosa from the door. She returned my greeting without looking up from the

frying and without much eagerness. Upon arriving at the living room, I settled my body next to Carlos' on one of the long black seats.

“Would you like something to drink?”

“No, thanks. I have to leave soon.”

“I'm going to have a beer, are you sure you don't want one?”

“No, no. I'm leaving right away,” I smiled.

Rosa warned him that the food would be ready in a few minutes and the old man left the kitchen grumbling. He sat down next to me, paid me and drank half a bottle of beer.

“I was so thirsty,” he excused himself while wiping his mouth with his hand.

When I reached into my pants for the small plastic bag, Carlos had finished the beer.

“Exactly fifteen grams.”

He thanked me for the home delivery and, as usual, invited me to use the cocaine with him.

“I'm sorry, my friend, but I'm running out of time. Monica is waiting for me for dinner, and if I'm late, you know...”

“I understand,” said Carlos. “I'll do the same, Rosa has already warned me.”

“Why don't we have some appetizers on Sunday? I also have to tell you something about the suppliers.”

“It's done for me, although I warn you that it won't be as difficult to catch me as before, I don't drink with both hands anymore.”

I glanced at my watch and quickly said goodbye to Carlos and Rosa, who, just as she greeted me, said goodbye to me without much enthusiasm. I believe she had never liked me. Perhaps because Carlos used drugs the first time with me and for her, I was responsible for his addiction, and of

hers, who used with Carlos for the first time. On the other hand, she really liked my wife. I, as a result of her aptitude, did not hold her in esteem either.

II

Carlos walked through the door of the tavern with punctuality. I had decided to go earlier for the purpose of reading the sports articles in the newspaper during two coffees with little sugar.

“How are you, my friend?” he asked me as he slowly put his arm around the expanse of my shoulders.

“I came by a little early. To read what was in the paper.”

“Your team won by four to zero, right?”

“Five,” I answered quickly. “Did you fall asleep on the last goal?”

“I had a snooze a couple of times and Rosa took the remote from me,” he smiled. “If your damn team had been losing, I wouldn't have fallen asleep. It's not usual to see your Atleti win comfortably. When they do, it's boring.”

“It's always the same with yours. You have your eyes closed when the game is over.”

“That's a good sign, no doubt,” he smiled.

We ordered two beers when we finished with the previous ones.

“Didn't your wife want to come?”

“No, she told me yesterday that Monica still had a slight fever.”

“She won't come if your wife doesn't. She's better now, isn't she?” he asked intrigued.

“Yes, she'll be better soon. Damn viruses…”

“What was it you had to tell me?” he asked as he took a maroon-colored cigarette from the pack.

The color of the smoke, exactly the same as the wrapper, intermittently hit his face. The smell of it caught my desire to smoke and I took out a cigarette myself. For some time now, I had been buying less harmful cigarettes. There was no lack of those who said they did not produce cancer, nor those who dared to assure that they had beneficial health effects. They gave off a greenish-bluish smoke that, in my opinion, was more pleasant than the vehement color of Carlos' cigarettes.

“Yes,” I replied before tasting it. “I have to change suppliers. Luna's boss is having problems with the flow of orders. He hasn't assured me that it's temporary. For the time being, he told me that he won't be able to offer me his services for a few months.”

“Where do you plan to get it from now?” he asked, placing his beer on the bar.

“I don't know yet. What do you recommend?”

“Well...” he thought for a few seconds. “You can go to Blanca's.”

“Blanca?” I answered somewhat exalted. “Is he still in the village?”

“Yes, probably. I haven't heard from him in almost two years.”

“I don't know, I have to think about it. His reputation has always given me respect.”

“That's true,” he replied. “It's the price to pay for his strict compliance.”

We ordered two beers when we were done with the previous ones.

“You should see the items that are arriving in the warehouse,” I said cheerfully. “From giant stuffed rats to superhero dolls dressed in flamenco dresses.”

“Is anyone able to buy that?” he answered with a chuckle.

“There are always people who end up buying it. The success of these things is unpredictable.”

At lunchtime we ordered some tapas, and then we continued drinking more beers. A little drunk, Carlos confessed to me that he had thought on many occasions about separating from his wife.

“It's so many years that it's difficult to remember them. It is inertia that does not allow us to change.”

“Come on, Carlitos,” I replied, surprised. “It wouldn't make sense for your relationship to end in any other way than being together.”

“Love is a coincidence that is never permanent,” he answered discreetly. “It is inertia, remember, inertia...”

Before the night began, we left the bar, concentrating on keeping our balance.

III

Mid-morning Tuesday, I got a call from my wife on my cell phone. I was sorting out some of those weird toys I had talked to Carlos about the previous Sunday. Nervously, she was trying to tell me that my friend was in the hospital in a coma.

When I heard her words, I had to sit down on a large cardboard box next to me. After a few seconds assigned to recover my heart, I did listen to how Monica had found out and why Carlos was like this.

Rosa had told her the news a few minutes ago. The doctors had determined that Carlos' current state had been provoked due to the use of some adulterated drug. Quickly, I thought of the order from a few days ago. Unsettled, I drove to the hospital.

The sky was a greenish color. A color I always associated with emotion and judgment. Rosa was sitting alone, in one of the six or seven little chairs that formed a white row next to the wall. Her hands were next to her head and her eyes could only see the floor.

“Rosa!” I called to her from a distance as I reached her.

She stared at me. She was a little disheveled and her face had aged a few more years.

“You're a scoundrel! You left my husband in a coma, you son of a bitch!”

Rosa rushed at me and grabbed my shirt with both hands.

“Son of a bitch, you are responsible for all of this!” she repeated without rest.

All the surprised people who were close to us observed us without moving from their places. Two doctors who were very close grabbed Rosa's strong arms.

“Madam, keep calm. Sit there and try to calm down,” said one of the doctors, pointing to the little white chairs next to us.

Rosa tried to free herself from the two doctors who had her restrained.

“You will never see my husband again in your life!” she shouted disconsolately. “Get out of here right now!”

I had to leave without being able to say a single word.

Rosa had invited my wife to visit him on a few occasions. She repeated that she didn't blame her and that she never wanted to see me again. Monica did not want to go unless it was with me, so she did not go to the hospital. So, she found out everything that happened to Carlos through the telephone. I had tried to visit him on several times. Sometimes Rosa spent her time wandering around the door of his room and the other times, when I didn't see her, I assumed she was taking care of him. In all of them, I never got close enough not to go unnoticed.

Chapter 5

I

The ten floors of the building were rectangles that decreased as they advanced towards the sky, forming a reddish pyramid-shaped facade. The first floors, longer than those piling up above them, were unaffordable due to their high prices. The cheapest, the tenth floor, was not to exceed one hundred rectangular feet. It had been almost three years since we had lived in one of the houses on the sixth floor.

Today was Saturday, a somewhat colder Saturday than the previous one, but as similar as all the others. It was getting dark and sitting on the balcony, Monica and I were smoking while chatting about the week's events. When Monica finished smoking, she began to mix with the cigarette butt, the yellowish ashes of her cigarette with the bluish-greenish ashes of mine. It was a habit she repeated whenever we went out on the balcony together.

“You don't get tired of mixing them,” I smiled as I stared at the ashtray.

“No,” she assured. “It relaxes me.”

“Wait,” I said as I got up from my chair to the bedroom.

I returned with a little silver box.

“Do you want to try them?” I asked her while I opened the box.

“What is it?”

The box was filled with five small and very thin cigarettes, no more than two inches. They had a very intense bluish color.

“I bought them a few days ago. I forgot to tell you...they burn very fast, in a couple of puffs. Do you want to try them?” I repeated, holding one of the cigarettes in my hand.

“Not now, I don't feel like it,” she answered.

Monica was an experimental drug user and I had never seen her develop dependence on any of them. I lit the cigarette and the blue smoke shot up to the ceiling. One puff was enough to finish half its length. I quickly deposited the ash in the ashtray before it fell out.

“It must be finished in less than two minutes,” I told her after blowing the smoke out of my nose.

“Is it too strong?” she asked.

“No, you hardly feel anything in your throat.”

I took another drag and left the tiny cigarette butt in the ashtray. Monica moved her chair next to me and leaned her head on my shoulder.

“Shall we go out for a while?”

“As you wish,” I answered, feeling the effects of the drug kick in.

I hugged Monica's body with one arm and with a hypnotic half-smile I stared for a few minutes at the moon, which was shining brighter and brighter while the night appeared. After some dinner, we went to *The Music*, which today had adopted the name of *´Disco Music´*. We walked down the stairs captivated by *Love's Theme* of Barry White. We ordered drinks and Monica asked me to dance. I always did it excessively badly, moving my arms away from my body, which was as straight as I could get it, throwing it back. Unlike me, Monica moved really well, coordinating her movements with the beat of the music. Songs by Leo Sayer, The Bee Gees, Van McCoy, Donna Summer, Gloria Gaynor, Michael Jackson, Chic, Diana Ross, Tavares, Anita Ward, Ottawan, Tina Charles, Electric Light Orchestra,

KC and The Sunshine Band, Van McCoy and The Trammps, among others, played.

We held out until four in the morning.

II

For more than two years, Luna had been selling me the drug that I always bought every three or four weeks. He was about fifty years old and always wore the same red cap on his head. The few times he walked, he did so at an exasperatingly slow pace due to his morbid obesity. Under his orders worked three corpulent boys who could not have been more than twenty-five or twenty-six years old. They lived next to him in the apartment where they were installed and where they very cautiously supplied the stuff. In order not to arouse the suspicions of their neighbors, they did not allow the same person to visit them more than once a month and the number of customers never exceeded five or six. In this way, with the customers acting as intermediaries, they had managed to generate a large sum of money without creating distrust in the other residents. That morning I pressed the doorbell a little nervous, aware that Luna's patience had run out. One of the young men opened the door.

“Come in,” he said after identifying me through the peephole.

He closed the door and after frisking me, went to tell Luna of my presence.

The other two boys were sitting on the couch, playing a video game among themselves. They greeted me and continued immersed in the soccer game. In one of the rooms, preserved by sliding doors, Luna had set up the office.

After waiting for a slightly longer period of time than usual, the young man who had opened the door let me in.

“What a pleasant surprise! I have the honor of receiving one of my best debtors.”

“How are you, Luna?” I answered, trying to omit his cheerful welcome.

“Allow me to be in a hesitant mood.”

He rested his hands behind his head while his pounds slid down the chair.

“I have brought you a good part of the debt. I need more time, I trust you understand.”

Luna smiled as he looked me straight in the eye.

After counting the money, he put his big finger on a piece of paper that he took out when I entered his office, from one of the drawers attached to his desk.

“One hundred and twenty-eight days... one hundred and seventeen days... your debt is the third highest, although by reducing it by about forty percent today, with luck you'll drop a few positions. You're in luck today, I'm going to sell you for the last time until you complete it.”

“All right, thank you,” I replied seriously.

Afterwards, I paid for my dope and Carlos' order.

“Don't close on the way out,” he asked me. “And don't forget the interests.”

III

When I got home, Monica was still gone.

I went to my room to take off my clothes and began to slowly unbutton the first button of my shirt, looking at myself without pause in the bedroom mirror. The mirror showed the face of a junkie, and at that moment, without knowing it, I realized that I was a drug addict.

“It had to have been me, damn it, it was for me!” I repeated relentlessly, hitting the closet violently with both arms. “He was not guilty of anything!”

A little calmer, I grabbed the baggie and sitting on the bed I stopped to look at it for a while. I turned my head from side to side. I regretted how lucky I had been not to have consumed before him and I thought that if I had been more astute, I would have foreseen Luna's intentions when he left me waiting in the room longer than usual, necessary to prepare the adulterated cocaine. I threw the baggie in the trash and waited for Monica to arrive. When she arrived, she found me on the couch, hunched over, with my hands on my head and my vision invaded by thoughts. She had just come from visiting Carlos after work. Hours before, Rosa had shouted me out of the hospital.

Very early, I pressed the entry phone. One of the boys dragged the door which he had secured with the chain.

“Let me in.”

“Wait,” he said, slamming the door in my face.

When he received Luna's approval and after checking me in, he let me in.

“I just needed a few more days! I just needed a little more time, all the other times I've always paid...”

I didn't finish my sentence when I received a punch that knocked me to the floor. Then the boy who had opened the door kicked me twice.

Luna was watching me from his office.

“Other times?” he asked rhetorically. “The other times your debts weren't even a third of what they are this time. Don't come here again without the money and let it be the last time you come in here shouting and disregarding the visiting protocol,” he said loudly. “Things only end well when they are done right. Will you be able to understand that? ...get him the hell out of here,” he ordered the muscleman. “And don't forget the interests.”

I was quickly lifted up and thrown out of the apartment.

IV

I was very nervous. Since Carlos went into a coma, I had not consumed anything. It had been three days since then, and sadness had taken over my life. Without suppliers, I decided to trust the recommendation he had made me a few days ago when we agreed to have a few beers, and become a client of the services Blanca offered in a territory reserved for a few dealers who had managed to make it the most important point of sale of drugs in the city.

I took the bus and getting off at one of its last stops, the closest to my destination, I started walking. To get to the village, I had to walk through a gigantic wasteland, where several families had lived many years ago in illegal constructions. Dirt roads and almost destroyed walls were the only remaining vestiges of that time.

For some time now, it had been called the city of spires. The abandoned wasteland was inhabited only by junkies. Some tried to stand upright and walked along the paths making great efforts not to fall to the ground; while others, the majority, remained seated and leaned against the walls, injecting the drug they had bought a couple of miles away. It was the only entrance to the village, so all customers were forced to cross it.

I lit a cigarette and hurried to get there as soon as possible. Many of the junkies who were sitting there had lost their consciousness, without giving them time to remove the needle hanging from their arms along with the remains of blood as a result of unsuccessful attempts to pierce themselves successfully. I thought that all those people, some time ago, would also

have crossed the huge wasteland like me, with the greater or lesser doubt that for them, too, there could be a room in this place. In the distance, I could glimpse an older man shooting water at the pigeons and sparrows that hovered by his side. A little closer, a very thin young man and another man did begin to argue over a needle that one of them was holding in his hand.

“This is not yours!” one of them scolded him.

“Give it to me, you bastard! You stole it from me!” replied the younger one, pushing him with what little strength he had.

At that moment, the other one stuck the needle he was holding into his head.

“There you go, sucker,” said the aggressor while spitting on him.

The young man fell to the ground with the needle embedded in the top of his skull.

Some of those who were around gradually approached and took him away. The boy, prostrate on the ground, was crying inconsolably. Two people removed the needle and tried to calm him down. I hesitated to approach, but decided to keep walking. A little over a mile away was the end of the wasteland. It connected with an old road protected by a few armed men, where no junkies were to be seen. Some were playing cards on folding tables and the others were walking or chatting among themselves.

Before passing through, I was thoroughly searched. About ten men with rifles, in front of the large wooden door, guarded the entrance. The village was protected by metal fences about thirteen feet high.

On top of the mounds that surrounded it, there were more people, some of them with sniper rifles.

“Hello,” I said to one of those who were leaning against the door.

“I'm here to see Blanca, it's the first time.”

“You have to talk to him,” he said as he pointed to a guy who was talking with two others.

I went to him and told him the same thing I told the first one.

“Wait here,” he said and went into the village.

He came back after five minutes and after patting me down, he escorted me to a little yellow two-story house. Three thugs stood guard at the door. The village had about twenty houses in close proximity to each other. All of them had similar activities, although each belonged to different suppliers. Along the sandy roads, among the customers, a few armed men walked. In the distance, I could make out another door identical to the one at the entrance. I went up to the second floor accompanied by one of the guards.

Blanca was seated. He was completely bald and had a glass eye under one of his plucked eyebrows.

The other eye had a very light blue color. He rested his arms on an elongated black table that held only a few papers, two pens and a picture of a guy who looked like Lucky Luciano. Around him, three bodyguards were engaged in different tasks.

“Sit down,” he said as he pointed to one of the two chairs on the other side of the table. “What's your name?”

“Victor. I come on behalf of Carlos Fernandez. He has spoken of you as an excellent professional.”

“Yes...he is a good friend. I've known him since he was a child. It's been at least two years since we've seen each other. How is he?” he asked interested.

“He's fine...fine for his age.”

“You're lying,” he answered after receiving a look from the only eye he still had. “What happened to him?”

“He had a little heart scare a few days ago, but he'll get over it,” I improvised, still amazed.

“Look kid, if you want to be our client, I do recommend you not to be untruthful in my presence. I'm going to explain you three simple rules by which we are governed, listen well because it will be the only time I do it. Here there are no debtors, we only sell to those who pay us. Don't try to play games with me either, because if you try, you and your family will already be dead. Finally, I do not want you to mention to anyone even the first of the words you need to express everything you see or hear here that is beyond the normality of the legal activity to which we are dedicated. If you break this last rule, we will be forced to apply the second one.”

“I understand,” I replied, realizing that Blanca's level of permissiveness differed greatly from Luna's.

“If you don't violate these simple rules, you can come as often as you like. We operate like any other business...sellers are in the business of selling and buyers are in the business of buying.”

I nodded and after a brief silence, he asked:

“Okay. What do you want?”

The same sum of money was not even enough to buy half the same amount as usual.

“If you want a ride to the city, it's fifty euros more. Otherwise, you're going to have to walk a few miles because you can't go back the way you came in.”

“All right.”

“Don't forget to say hello to Carlos.”

“Yes. I'll tell him.”

I held out my hand and walked with the bodyguard assigned to accompany me. We left the village through the other gate, which was also

protected by a few armed men. Afterwards, we got into one of the cars parked next to it. All the others belonged to different suppliers providing the same service.

In a few minutes we reached the town.

V

In the middle of the morning, I received a message from Carlos.

He informed me that he had been resting at home for three nights. He also invited me to visit him, taking advantage of a few minutes of his wife's absence.

“You look well, how are you?” asked as I closed the door with an apologetic smile.

He had been in a coma for four days, three weeks ago.

Contrary to expectations, he had hardly aged at all.

“I'm thinner than before, I even look better,” he joked.

Carlos shuffled his feet very slowly, but he made an effort to get to the couch as quickly as possible. He had lost a few pounds, but his pregnant belly had not disappeared.

We sat very close to each other.

After watching him for a few seconds, I apologized.

“I'm so sorry, Carlos. I wish this had happened to me.”

“The thing that weakened me the most was obeying all my wife's orders,” he replied. “I can't recommend it.”

I smiled and shook my head sideways, expressing my admiration for his great sense of humor.

“Monica has been informing me of your progression all these days. I tried to visit you and I understand that your wife didn't let me. I even believe she thinks I knew the drug was adulterated and that's why I didn't want to use with you that day.”

“Maybe I'm right when I think she's getting more twisted every day,” he replied with a laugh. “I don't want you to blame yourself anymore, it happens,” he said seriously, looking me in the eye.

He wouldn't have needed to tell me that. When he opened the door and I saw his eyes I knew he didn't hold any grudge.

“I'm sorry I lied to you about the suppliers, but I didn't want to alarm you.”

“The only thing I didn't realize was the level of debt. We old people have a great advantage over the young, and that is experience. Listen to my advice, don't stop taking care of Monica. She's next, you know how it goes...Do you want me to lend you some money?”

“Don't worry, I already have the money,” I said, even though I knew it would have no deterrent effect on him.

“Are you sure?” he insisted suspiciously. “If you want, I can lend you some.”

“I'm sure,” I replied, trying to believe my own lie. “You have a big heart. I'm so glad everything turned out well.”

Carlos put his hand on the back of my neck.

“Did you buy again?”

“I followed your recommendation and went to the village. I've seen Blanca a couple of times. He sends his regards.”

“Tell him I'm fine, because if he asked about me, he probably guessed from your face that something had happened to me. He always had an uncanny ability to sense certain things.”

“That's how it was,” I answered, surprised.

“Victor, you're going to have to leave now. Rosa could arrive at any moment. She went to visit a friend of hers who is in the hospital and if she comes early, I don't want you both to give me a hard time.”

“Of course,” I immediately reasoned.

Before leaving, Carlos kissed me and insisted on offering me money if I needed it.

When it was time to visit Luna, I didn't even have half of the remaining part of the debt. I decided not to show up and wait a few more days until I received the money for the next bonus payment. Only four days had passed since I had let Luna's commitment slip when I received a call from an unknown number.

It warned me that my wife was kidnapped, the amount I needed to get her back, much more than I owed, and the time, no more than three days to collect the money.

After hanging up the phone, I had the feeling of not believing anything. I knew the level of exigency with which Luna worked and I had a hard time believing that, with him, Carlos' forecasts were correct. Therefore, during these days, I had mistakenly underestimated many measures necessary to avoid this situation.

Subsequently, I tried to communicate with her, without success, because her cell phone had been turned off. As the minutes passed, I was somewhat more reassured to know that by complying with the conditions they had set, nothing would happen to her. I needed all this to have never happened. I hated everything that did not allow me to foresee with normal lucidity, situations that I would have been able to predict some time ago.

Nervously, I went to the drawer where I always kept the cocaine.

There was nothing left. I had consumed a few hours ago and I didn't even remember it. Intuitively, I picked up some money I had set aside to pay the debt and tried to move to the village.

I was unable to do so. I fell to my knees on the ground while squeezing the bills with both hands. Lying on the floor, twisted like a child with my head close to my knees, I began to cry inconsolably.

Chapter 6

I

In all this time I did not go to Luna's apartment, I was afraid that Monica would suffer reprisals.

At half past eight in the evening, at the top of the Parc del Cielo, next to the statue dedicated to a Knight bearing the Order of the French Legion of Honor, one of his subordinates would be waiting for me to pick up the money. I had sold the car and a handful of gold rings and bracelets that I had owned for many years.

I headed out on foot. The Park was nearby, about thirty minutes from my house. I was ascending a small street attached to a vast wasteland that had no lighting, only that which came from the adjacent street lamps, at the time I perceived some strange sounds coming from within. It seemed that someone was crawling in one of the few thick bushes that remained to my left. I entered slowly, I could hardly see anything and still, listening to my breathing, without moving any muscle, I waited to receive the same sounds again. There were none and I immediately returned to the sidewalk. Before arriving and alerted by the snapping noise of some dry branches that I had stepped on, I instinctively looked towards the foot to find out what it was.

Rosa was walking down the longest street surrounding the wasteland, dragging a plastic bag in each hand. She had just come from buying a few last minute groceries. At that moment, alerted by the noise generated by

those dry branches, she turned her head and saw my face in profile, looking at my shoes.

After checking what I had stepped on, I left almost running from the shortcut with the aim of recovering the little time I had lost and get to the top of the park as soon as possible. When I reached the statue, the boy who was supposed to be waiting for me was leaning against it, on one of the arms. I went to talk to him and he quickly took out of his jacket pocket something gassy that he shot at my face. I fell disoriented and fainted.

It was pitch dark when I woke up. Lying under a few trees, I was opening my eyes. Dazed, I realized I didn't have the money. I returned home, not understanding why they had reneged on the agreement.

Early in the morning, I went to Luna's house. No one answered the call and after going upstairs, I banged on the door and the doorbell repeatedly. I asked about the tenants to some of the neighbors who were coming out, impressed by the noises. I lit a cigarette and on the nearest stairs, with my hands on my head, I sat, hopelessly, waiting for nothing.

II

I turned on the television and one of the news programs interrupted all my thoughts about my wife. It reported the discovery of the lifeless body of a young woman, inside the wasteland that I had bordered that same night. The doctors determined the time of death to be around eight o'clock in the evening. Automatically, I remembered those mysterious noises. Three days after inhaling the gas thrown in my face, I reported Monica's missing person to the police. I felt obliged to do so, after waiting uselessly for any information about her.

Four days after making the report, the phone rang while I was sitting on the end of the couch, smoking a cigarette. Cautiously, the police told me that Monica's body had been found in a river. I put the cigarette in the ashtray and hung up the phone without saying a word. I don't know if I didn't want to move or if I couldn't move. I remained seated in the same position I was in before I received the call. I was dead just like her. However, my heart was still beating.

Without even sliding down my face, tears flooded my eyes. I don't know how many hours I sat like that, still, static, as if anything I could do or say would distinguish me from what she was now.

Intense rays of sunlight, changing to violet, almost purple, after passing through the colorful glass of the living room, hit my eyes. I went in search of all the photographs of my wife scattered around the house and placed them in the living room. In all of them she was laughing, and in some of them, the older ones, she had curly black hair. Without saying a word, her two blue eyes looked at me, as when she was next to me.

I had seen Carlos at the funeral. He told me that Rosa had preferred not to be near me, the one she considered Monica's murderer. I could see her far

away, about two hundred and fifty feet away, hiding her accusing eyes with giant sunglasses. That day and the one I spent at the police station were the only days I left the house. Before they questioned me, I got rid of my cell phone, to avoid being linked to Luna. They asked me why I reported the disappearance so late. They knew Monica had died three or four days before I made the report. They also insisted on whether anyone had contacted me during the abduction.

Without respite, television and the press did not stint in showing everyone their most sensationalist guts and speculating about the same murderer for the two victims. I thought countless times that I could have prevented the murder of the young woman who had been stabbed several times. Then I would excuse myself, thinking that it could have taken me as long as it took to get to the exchange on time.

III

I spent my days using narcotics that transformed everything around me. Many nights I woke up at the same time, five past five, which on the digital clock translated into a distress message. After that, I could no longer sleep. At night was when all the failures were remembered the most. Whenever I woke up from a nightmare, I discovered that life was not much better than that. Other times, I also heard the sound of the doorbell ringing and Carlos' voice repeating my name. They were such distant sounds, that it took me a while to discover that they were part of reality, until Carlos and I coincided near the door. Some leftover food and a few drugs scattered on the living room table was what my home had become.

Carlos gave me a hug.

“Come in,” I said, pointing inside the house.

As he walked awkwardly, he analyzed everything around him.

“This is a mess,” I apologized. “So, it was true that you've been coming here all these days. I'm sorry I didn't open the door. I've been so stoned I couldn't. Did you come on foot?” I asked worriedly. “You're still too weak to walk.”

Carlos picked up a small bag of cocaine that was ajar and said:

“Victor, you have to stop consuming all this garbage. This is not a good way to console yourself.”

“It helps me to live,” I said, looking at both his hands.

“Don't talk nonsense!” he shouted angrily. “Don't you realize that this shit has ruined everything.”

“It wasn't only the drug, Carlos, it was me too.”

He immediately understood that it was not the time to scold me. He got up and raised the blinds. Instantly, the reddish blue colored clarity was devouring the walls.

“What are you thinking about?”

“In the beginning,” I answered after a while. “When we began to use drugs.”

“I'm going to tell you something,” he said as he sat down. “Rosa has always held a grudge against you for that. For using for the first time with you and not having done it with Blanca, when we were young and he started dealing. She doesn't understand that I was capable of not doing it with him and after so many years, doing it with you. That's why he has always considered you a bad influence on me.”

“I've often thought so,” I answered.

Carlos smiled and after a while, he asked:

“What are you going to do, are you going to go and look for them?”

“Yes,” I answered flatly, “I don't want to lie to you again.”

He nodded shyly, as if giving me his approval.

Between the two of us we tidied up the living room a little; then, by means of a cell phone message, Rosa told him that the food would be ready in a short time.

“In a few days I will see you again,” said Carlos. “I'm sure I'll be lucky and you'll open the door for me.”

“I promise you that I will try to quit, I really will,” I said after receiving the message. “I know that my promises have been devalued over time, but everything can be changed.”

“Goodbye, Victor,” he said putting his hand on my shoulder.

“Thank you for coming,” I replied. “You help me to go on. One person alone is worthless.”

I began to visit regularly a bar called *The Temple*.

I also went back to *The Music*. The last occasion I was there was when I danced with Monica for the last time. Every Thursday *The Music* spent its hours on Louisiana music. The mechanics of the pub had not changed for years; until twelve-thirty, one or two groups would play the style of music assigned to that day and then the deejay would continue with the most representative recordings of the genre. When I arrived, a group of youngsters were showing their determination to trace Django Reinhardt's *Minor Swing*.

I had a few drinks during the night, surrounded by the sounds of trumpet players like Dizzy Gillespie, Joe Oliver, Louis Armstrong, Miles Davis, Chet Baker or Herb Alpert; saxophonists like Charlie Parker, Marion Brown, Stan Getz or Ben Webster; and guitarists like Kenny Burrell, John Mclaughlin and the real Django Reinhardt.

IV

Leaning back in his chair, Blanca repeatedly bounced a small ivory-colored rubber ball against the table. In a short time, I had become one of his best buyers.

“I need you to find a guy they call Luna. He has worked for many years with three boys in a house on Barbadelo Street. I'm sorry I can't give you more information,” I said after describing him. “I also need a gun with a silencer, two cartridges, a tool with which I can open any door and something with which I can immobilize several people at once.”

“Good,” said Blanca. “Let's take it one step at a time. I know the guy you're talking about, Luna. He was selling in the village a few years ago, a short time ago. He was always going around with three boys who couldn't have been more than eighteen years old. If they haven't left here, a priori, it won't be difficult to find them. As for the last thing you asked me, I will tell you that there is a very small device,” said Blanca simulating its size of between one and two inches, with his index finger and thumb. “That emanates a kind of gas, of course soundless and smellless, that could make anyone collapse.”

“It's perfect,” I said, satisfied.

“Everything is going to be a bit expensive for you. If you want me to get down to it tomorrow, you have to give me at least one hundred and twenty thousand euros, which is half of what it's going to cost you. If my forecasts are not delayed, in three or four weeks you will have everything ready.

Exceptionally, and due to my friendship with Carlos, the rest of the money can be paid later.”

“Thank you very much,” I said after counting all the bills and paying half the amount. “I will come back when three or four weeks have passed.”

Blanca nodded in agreement.

“Are you going to walk back?” he asked.

“Yes,” I said. “I'll go for a walk.”

Since Monica died, my boss had increased my salary by almost thirty percent. It was his way of taking pity on me and preventing me from resigning my job. Also, for the first time, he had granted me several advances on salary which, together with the life insurance compensation, helped me to pay for my assignments.

When four weeks had passed, I returned to the village.

Blanca showed me a wooden box from which he took out a sheet of paper.

“I was right when I told you that it would not be difficult to find them.”

Then he put on the table an automatic gun, two cartridges, the silencer and showed me a black device, very thin and square, the size he had simulated. It had an elongated red button on one edge, and almost imperceptible openings on the other.

“The exposure to the gas must be continuous, eleven or twelve hours is enough. It has a range of around sixty-five feet. Placing it under the door will suffice. The mechanism is very simple, you turn it on by pressing the red button,” he said, pointing to it. “But remember that you can't turn it off once you've turned it on.”

Finally, he pulled some gray rectangular strips about three inches long out of the box.

“As you insert it into the lock, it will adapt to its shape and you will have a replica of the key. Once you remove it, it will no longer be useful, they are made of a material that does not allow them to be reused.”

“How many do you want?”

“I'll take all of them,” I answered after foreseeing that the three that rested in Blanca's hand would be enough in case any of them failed.

“When you have finished, I recommend that you get rid of everything, including the gun.”

“I will do so,” I agreed.

V

Today, the sky dawned red.

They say it is the color that corresponds to the lowest frequency of light detectable by the human eye. It is the color of maniacs, of energy and emotions. Also, they say it symbolizes hatred and cruelty. I had let my beard grow for more than a month and on the little hair I had, I had installed a wig of short curly hair. Finally, I bought some pliers, tape and ropes.

Luna had moved to a small village in Toledo. According to the report, he was still living with the three young men. Early in the morning, I moved to the address indicated. I arrived mid-morning. It was a small old building not even four floors high. Almost at dusk, I entered it without difficulty. I localized the door of the second floor where they had to be lodged. With the lights off and avoiding a run-in with any neighbor, I tried to verify that there was no mistake in the address Blanca had given me.

It didn't take me long to hear Luna's voice behind the worn door; then, I inserted and activated the tiny device under it. I spent the night waiting for the morning in the highest part of the building, next to the access door to the roof. Around nine o'clock, I descended to the second floor. The door had a single lock. The foil slid into it without difficulty, as if it were children's play dough. I placed the palm of my hand under the lock to prevent the rest of the key material from falling to the floor. I turned the key twice and the door opened comfortably. Then I cut with the pliers a chain that was blocking me from moving forward. I extracted the copy of the key from the lock and entered the apartment. In the small armchair in the center of the

living room, one of his boys was sitting asleep. Luna was on the bed in one of the bedrooms. He was sound asleep, dressed in indigo pajamas and his red cap. In the spare room, his two subordinates rested dressed in yesterday's clothes. I bound them all hand and foot, placed a tape on their lips and led them to the living room floor. After a few minutes of slapping Luna, I got him to wake up. I then repeated the procedure with the others. They sleepily watched me from the floor. After a while, I removed the tape from Luna's lips.

“Victor,” he said, frightened. “Is that you?”

“Why did you kill her?” I asked uncompromisingly.

“It was an accident, Victor, a coincidence,” he answered in surprise. “She became very nervous when we went to untie her. I haven't gained anything from all this. I've had to change city and clients. And what did you want me to do with the money? Leave it there? We had to pay off your debt.”

“She was already fucking dead, why did you have to rape her!” I said, grabbing the collar of his shirt. Luna didn't answer. I covered his mouth again and shot his right leg. He squirmed while the others looked at him in fear. After a while, I removed the tape again.

“I didn't do it, God!” he said, twitching.

“Who then?”

“He...Campos,” he snorted as he stared at his closest partner.

“You all consented.”

“What did you want us to do, nothing was going to change.”

I covered his lips again and shot him four times in the chest. Afterwards, I turned to the boy next to him. He looked the youngest of them all. Sitting down, he was looking at Luna's body.

“Is what he said true?” I asked.

“You killed him, you son of a bitch!” he shouted in agitation. “Yes, I raped her and I swear, even if she didn't move, she enjoyed it while I was fucking her!” he confessed angrily.

I covered his mouth and shot at his genitals. The boy who had his hands tied behind his back, rolled violently on the floor, running over Luna's body. The other two became more and more nervous. I fired eight shots at them. Four each. They died instantly. I grabbed a chair and sat down in front of Campos, who had stopped moving. Faster and faster, the blood that spurted from all the bodies was soaking the floor. I lifted my shoes and attached them to the front legs of the chair. I stayed like that for a long time, watching his gaze fade. Then, when he was almost dead, I switched the cartridge to the gun and fired five shots into his chest. Even though it was too late to regret it, nothing inside me had changed. Yes, I had gotten the information I needed, but I also probably would have gotten it by telling the police everything that had happened.

VI

Monica's hands were tied to the chair she had been sitting on since last night.

She was being held in a tiny room with no access to sunlight. It would be no later than three o'clock in the afternoon. At half past eight the exchange would take place.

“Come on, we are leaving,” said Campos.

She tried to untie her and frightened, fearing that these were her last minutes of life, she began to shake strongly in the chair. Campos, easily angered, hit her with the gun in order to reduce her movements. Involuntarily, the gun hit Monica's left temple, causing her instant death.

The blood from the wound ran down her neck, seeping through her shirt. Campos stopped to stare at her for a few seconds. Then he touched her tits and penetrated her with force. Luna was waiting outside, in the street, and in view of his partner's delay, he went to the hiding place to look for him. Campos was still penetrating Monica's body.

“What the fuck are you doing!” Luna shouted as she stepped through the door.

Quickly, he called his other two subordinates. Meanwhile, Luna pulled Campos out of the hiding place.

“Why did you do this, you fucking maniac! you fucking maniac! you fucking maniac!” he shouted, relentlessly hitting Campos, who was lying half-naked on a sofa and crying non-stop.

Luna was still beating with his obese arms on his subordinate's face. The boys tried to calm him down while holding his huge arms.

VII

For some months now, Rosa had dedicated herself to compiling all the pages of the newspapers that were related to the murder of the young woman, keeping the clippings in a folder beside the recipes. Every time she read them and remembered me in the wasteland, she became more convinced that I had participated in some way in it. Rosa mixed up all her suspicions and decided to settle her everlasting personal scores, taking revenge on me through Lara, the young woman's sister.

The clock had recently struck twenty past eleven. I think it was Thursday, my last memory goes back to Tuesday night and I was in the habit of not dying for more than two days in a row...